

CHAPTER 3

Save Your Money, Save Your Life

People who are good with money, as my mother was, know how to say no. But mostly, they know how to live within their means. I define that as living just below what you can afford so that you always have extra. That extra gap is what is saved. That's the idea I want you to wrap your head around. People who live within—or even better, *below*—their means are good with money. And they *enjoy* the feeling of plenty around them. They get used to that feeling, so being financially overextended creates physical unease. And it's a true physical phenomenon. The stress of debt and financial hardship takes a serious toll on our health, on our relationships, and on our ability to earn the money we need to get out of that hole. A few years ago, an Associated Press–AOL Health poll found a link between money problems and a high rate of ulcers, migraines, Type 2 diabetes, and heart disease. People under stress also tend to smoke and drink more and sleep a lot less. So you see the catch-22. Financial health and personal health are deeply related.

The 90-Day Number is a way for you to diagnose that problem and get a handle on the health of your cash flow. It's also a way to break that consumer trance and begin stanching the flow of money out. Now we're going to channel some of the excess into a savings account, which for some people is even harder to do than investing, and it's certainly not as fun as spending.

So here's my challenge to those of you who don't think you can save money: Try saving a set amount of money for *only three months*. Don't think of it as a lifetime adjustment. Consider it temporary